

✓ FLOATING FLOWERS

Water lily flowers are hermaphrodite – they have both male and female organs. Pollen from the male parts can fertilize ovules in the female reproductive parts, so they can “self-pollinate”. However, female parts mature slightly before the flower starts releasing pollen. This increases the chances of flowers being fertilized by pollen carried by insects.



✓ LEAVES

The water lily has large leaves, up to 35 cm (14 in) in diameter. Unlike most leaves, their stomata (breathing pores) are on the upper surface, which has a water-repellent coating.

furled
young leaf

aerenchyma

^ FLOWER

The flowers have numerous white petals and bright yellow stamens, and can grow to 20 cm (8 in) in diameter.

sepal

stamen

petal

seeds

< OVARY SECTION

The female reproductive organs (consisting of ovules, ovary, and stigma) are fused together. Cavities contain ovules, which turn into seeds when fertilized.

^ STEM SECTION

Stems have longitudinal air spaces (aerenchyma), as well as structural tissue, creating buoyancy and allowing oxygen to circulate.

WHITE WATER LILY

Nymphaea alba

One of about 75 wild species of water lily, this handsome plant lives in still or slow-flowing water, casting a deep shade with its rounded, glossy leaves. It grows in water up to 1.5 m (5 ft) deep, and flowers in mid- to late summer, producing a succession of pure white blooms. Each flower lasts for three to four days, opening in the morning and closing by late afternoon. They attract pollinating beetles, which often spend the night inside the flowers, before being released at dawn. White water lilies are useful to water animals: pond snails glue their eggs to the underside of the leaves, and fish hide beneath them, avoiding predatory birds. After the flowers are pollinated, they produce buoyant seeds. These float for several weeks, before sinking into the mud.

SIZE Leaf diameter 10–35 cm (4–14 in)

HABITAT Ponds, streams, lakes, backwaters

DISTRIBUTION Europe

LEAF TYPE Simple, orbicular with a basal notch